

future games, we're bound to see visual improvements as well as developers spend some time with the new API. They also have 30 per cent of performance headroom to work with, which should lead to a noticeable hike in eye-candy. That being said, if you're not a hardcore gamer looking to play the latest and upcoming titles, you can easily



ATI HD5870

make do with an older generation DX 10-based graphics card. DX 9 graphics cards are still available, but they're not really worth it, since the price difference between them and the entry-level DX 10 cards is hardly anything.

The way I see it, audiences for graphic cards can be divided into four categories.

1. Those who are buying a basic PC and have basic needs including some multimedia usage including the odd game
2. People who are buying a slightly more powerful PC for multimedia and also want to play some games
3. Casual gamers who want to play all the latest games with fair levels of detail
4. Gaming junkies who demand the best gaming experience and therefore will be willing to invest a sizeable chunk of dough in a top-end graphics card

If you're a regular PC user, whose usage pattern is thus: a lot of surfing, some movies, the odd game you should look for something basic and priced at within Rs. 3,000. This includes cards based on NVIDIAs GeForce 9300 GS and 9400 GT GPUs – both of which are good buys. ATI's Radeon HD 4350 and 4650 GPUs are also available. Look for a card with 256 MB of VRAM – you will not need anything more, and do not opt for cards based on the above-mentioned chipsets with more (than 256 MB) memory unless the price difference is minimal – say Rs. 300 or thereabouts. Be on the lookout for dealers who will try to sell you a 512 MB or 1 GB option of such entry-level GPUs – this won't help your cause any and you will end up spending more uselessly. Look for connectivity, especially if you are building an HTPC, HDMI is a must and these cards are very well suited to HTPC users, and will easily display 1080p content on your HDTV.

Many readers write in to me saying they want something basic, within Rs. 6,000 but they're looking to play the occasional game as well. Remember that none of the cards mentioned in the previous category will suffice if playing